Khrushchev's letter of the previous day. President Kennedy was the first to grasp what might be going on. "He may be putting out another letter," he told his advisers, referring to Khrushchev.[1]

Kennedy was right. The newswires were transmitting Nikita Khrushchev's new letter just released by Radio Moscow. There was a good reason why Kennedy was the first to grasp what was going on. If for Khrushchev throwing Turkey into the equation was a spontaneous last-minute decision, for Kennedy it was anything but an unexpected move on the part of Moscow. Turkey had been on his mind from the very start of the crisis, not as a propaganda tool but as a way of overcoming it. Kennedy, who believed that the nuclear-armed Jupiter missiles placed in Turkey by his predecessor, General Eisenhower, were outdated and useless, had been thinking of trading them off for the Soviet missiles in Cuba long before the arrival of Khrushchev's offer. He discussed that possibility as his preferred diplomatic scenario with his friend the UK ambassador to Washington, David Ormsby-Gore, on the afternoon of October 21, the day before he first addressed the nation. He was not sure back then whether he would be able to pull it off politically, but now it seemed the opportunity had finally presented itself.[2]

"Where are we with our conversations with the Turks?" Kennedy asked his advisers. "Hare says that is absolutely anathema as a matter of prestige and politics," responded Undersecretary of Defense Paul Nitze, referring to the reports from the American ambassador to Turkey, Raymond A. Hare. Nitze was clearly on Hare's side: the move could raise the question of whether the United States was going to denuclearize NATO. Kennedy knew that the unity of NATO would be in jeopardy if the Europeans assumed that the Americans were removing their nuclear shield and abandoning them to the Soviets. Nitze offered Kennedy a possible solution to his problem: if he told Khrushchev that he was prepared to discuss Turkey once the Cuban crisis was solved. Kennedy was skeptical. "No, I do not think we can," he told Nitze with regard to his proposal.

McGeorge Bundy suggested to ignore Khrushchev's proposal about Turkey and focus on his earlier letter, which did not mention it. "There's nothing wrong with our posture in sticking to that line," declared Bundy. Kennedy disagreed. He did not believe that Khrushchev would remove